

Jeans: From Genoa To James Dean [B1]

Dal porto della Genova medievale a capo presente in qualsiasi armadio: il tutto grazie a un adattamento fonetico, Marlon Brando e James Dean.

Everything begins with the great textile tradition of Genoa on the northwestern coast of Italy. As early as the Middle Ages, the people of Genoa produced a strong [fabric](#) made of [cotton](#) imported from the eastern Mediterranean. It was used to make clothes for [sailors](#) and port workers, as well as sacks, [sails](#) and covers for [goods](#). The first ambassadors of this [garment](#) were [therefore](#) Genoese [sailors](#) who wore it on their journeys to Mediterranean ports in France and Spain, to England and around the world.

A DURABLE GARMENT

At that time, it was common for imported [goods](#) to take their name from the place they came from. For this reason, the French identified this [fabric](#) as gênes (that is, Genoa in French.) In English pronunciation, this term was transformed into 'jeans'. The first written record of the word [dates back to](#) 1567. The [spread](#) of jeans increased greatly with textile industrialisation in the 18th and 19th centuries. In the 19th century, this [garment](#) arrived in America [through](#) immigration and transatlantic [trade](#). Language

Gossip: The Social Glue Il pettegolezzo non è certo un'abitudine dei giorni nostri: ce lo dimostra l'origine della parola 'gossip'. Molly Malcolm, Graziella Del Ciuco

MR. LEVI STRAUSS

A German-born American [fabric](#) merchant and entrepreneur named Levi Strauss immediately understood the potential of this almost indestructible [garment](#). It seemed perfect for [gold prospectors](#), miners, railway workers, and cowboys. The idea of adding the famous [copper](#) rivets to [strengthen](#) points of stress and [wear](#), such as the pockets, came from Jacob Davis, an

American tailor of Latvian origin. However, he did not have the sixty-eight dollars needed to register the patent, so he contacted Levi Strauss, who supplied the fabric. They became partners and in 1873 they filed the patent together.

HOW DO YOU SAY...?

A intuito. By the seat of your pants.

BLUE JEANS

The fabric made by the Genoese was probably not the typical blue of modern jeans. It was mostly a natural hue, that is, brownish, beige, or other rough tones that were resistant to dirt. The blue colour we associate with jeans today arrived later, in the 19th century, with American industrial production and the use of indigo dye, which was relatively cheap, long-lasting and easy to find. Most importantly, it was very effective at hiding dirt.

YOUTH ICON

Until World War Two, jeans were still only a humble work uniform, and no one could imagine their future fame. It was only in the 1950s that they conquered young people and then the world. The decisive moment came through rough American cinema: when Marlon Brando and James Dean wore them in *The Wild One* and *Rebel Without a Cause*, respectively, jeans immediately became popular with youth culture.

EGALITARIAN GARMENT

From there, it was a short step to becoming a symbol of counterculture and rebellion among teenagers in the 1960s. Jeans turned into a kind of uniform that expressed rejection of conventions and formal clothing, based on a simple and powerful egalitarian idea: a garment equally worn by men and women, by the rich and the poor. And soon this symbol of Western culture

would break down geographical barriers and become the most widespread item of clothing in the world.

Glossary

- **fabric** = tessuto, stoffa
- **sailors** = marinai
- **trade** = commercio
- **copper** = rame
- **strengthen** = rafforzare
- **wear** = usura
- **tailor** = sarto
- **rough** = grezzi
- **therefore** = quindi
- **filed** = depositare un brevetto
- **dirt** = sporco
- **dye** = tinta, colorante
- **long-lasting** = resistente
- **humble** = umile
- **cotton** = cotone
- **sails** = vele
- **goods** = merci
- **dates back to** = risalire a
- **spread** = diffusione
- **garment** = capo d'abbigliamento
- **gold prospectors** = cercatori d'oro
- **Latvian** = lettone
- **hue** = tonalità
- **break down geographical barriers** = abbattere barriere